JAMMU AND KASHMIR

OMAR'S EASE OF BUSINESS LAW CREATES UNEASE

It promises what reformers always sought: a clean-up of regulatory cholesterol. But civil groups, planners and ecologists worry its sweep may scar Kashmir forever

By **Ishfaq Tantry**



ANI

NEW WAVE CM Omar Abdullah chairs meeting on ease of doing business in the state, Srinagar, Sept. 1

needs investment and employment, but it also needs food security, protected apple orchards, functioning drainage systems, healthy ecosystems," they say. Ganai says "the stated objectives—ease of living and ease of doing business—appear contradictory". A future aggravated by "dust pollution" does not bode well for Kashmir, he adds.

Leader and MLA Waheed-ur-Rehman Para, who opposed the bill in the assembly, reiterates his concerns. "It turns Kashmir and its fragile ecology into commercial property and industry," he told INDIA TODAY. "Shops and commercial spaces can now come up inside residential areas. Only Red and Orange category industries and a few heavy businesses like storage, freight, night clubs and liquor shops are kept out. Everything else can open next to your home." Also, a 24-metre residential building can rise without Floor Area Ratio or coverage limits; with a certificate from a government-approved consultant, malls of the same size will need no government approval.

Takeaways

- **J&K passes Ease of Doing Business Bill, with a sweeping scope**
- **Arms CM with wide powers to bypass Master Plan, norms**
- **Critics fear it may damage human, ecological landscapes Valley's**

"This puts Kashmir's residential areas up for sale and puts both our ecology and our demography at risk. We lived through the 2014 floods. We know what happens when drains choke and wetlands are built over. This law worsens that risk," he adds. "Who will check the person who signs the certificate? Investment is welcome, but not at the cost of people's homes and safety. Remove planning rules, and we'll be paying for it the next time the water rises." Revealingly, he points out, the bill originated from the Housing and Urban Develop-